SCULPTURE, POTTERY AND ICONOGRAPHY

METHOD FIRST: READ OBJECT → HARAPPAN OBJECTS AND LABEL → POTTERY CHRONOLOGY AND LIMIT → MAURYAN POLISH AND POPULAR → THREE-SCHOOL COMPARISON → ANICONISM AND ICONIC SHIFT

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

◆ PRIMARY CORE FLOW ◆ SUBORDINATE EXTRA ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g2 and all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00 METHOD FIRST: READ OBJECT BEFORE MEANING

METHOD FIRST · READ OBJECT BEFORE MEANING · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 1/12 · READING CHAIN MATERIAL AND TECHNIQUE · SITE CONTEXT · CROSS-SITE COMPARISON · SUPPORTED MEANING · EVIDENCE LIMIT

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 1/12: METHOD FIRST

READING CHAIN material and technique → posture / gesture → attribute / emblem → patron / inscription

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 1/12: METHOD FIRST
- READING CHAIN material and technique
- posture / gesture
- attribute / emblem
- patron / inscription

MECHANISM

- site context
- cross-site comparison
- supported meaning
- evidence limit
- WHY IT MATTERS

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- The same motif changes meaning across chronology and setting.
- Description must come before identification, and identification before inference.
- The answer remains strong only if one explicit limit is stated.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The answer remains strong only if one explicit limit is stated.

01

STAGE 01 HARAPPAN OBJECTS AND LABEL CAUTION

HARAPPAN OBJECTS AND LABEL CAUTION · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 2/12 · HARAPPAN OBJECT BANK · HARAPPAN CORPUS STEATITE · SO-CALLED PASHUPATI SEAL · BEARDED PRIEST BRONZE · DANCING GIRL · KALIBANGAN BULL TERRACOTTA

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 2/12: HARAPPAN OBJECT BANK

HARAPPAN CORPUS steatite → so-called Pashupati seal / Bearded Priest bronze → Dancing Girl / → CONTROL RULES → Undeciphered script blocks certainty about Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King.

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 2/12: HARAPPAN OBJECT BANK
- HARAPPAN CORPUS steatite → so-called Pashupati seal / Bearded Priest bronze → Dancing Girl / Kalibangan bull terracotta → female figurines / models

MECHANISM

- CONTROL RULES
- Undeciphered script blocks certainty about Pashupati, Mother Goddess and Priest-King.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Lost-wax technique is real continuity; fixed religious meaning is not.
- Cow and lion are absent from the verified Harappan seal-and-terracotta trap bank.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cow and lion are absent from the verified Harappan seal-and-terracotta trap bank.

02

STAGE 02 POTTERY CHRONOLOGY AND LIMIT

POTTERY CHRONOLOGY AND LIMIT · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 3/12 · POTTERY RAIL · NEOLITHIC COARSE WARE · CHALCOLITHIC PAINTED WARES (AHAR · HARAPPAN RED WARE WITH BLACK PAINTING · PAINTED GREY WARE · NORTHERN BLACK POLISHED WARE

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 3/12: POTTERY RAIL

Neolithic coarse ware → Chalcolithic painted wares (Ahar / Malwa / Jorwe) → Harappan red ware with black painting → Painted Grey Ware

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 3/12: POTTERY RAIL
- Neolithic coarse ware
- Chalcolithic painted wares (Ahar / Malwa / Jorwe)

MECHANISM

- Harappan red ware with black painting
- Painted Grey Ware
- Northern Black Polished Ware

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Pottery is strongest for chronology, craft and material culture.
- Pottery alone cannot prove theology, dynasty or language.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pottery alone cannot prove theology, dynasty or language.

03

STAGE 03 MAURYAN POLISH AND POPULAR CULT LINE

MAURYAN POLISH AND POPULAR CULT LINE · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 4/12 · MAURYAN TO POST-MAURYAN · IMPERIAL LINE PILLARS · STATE AUTHORITY · RITUAL LINE · NATURE CULTS · ABSORPTION INTO MAJOR TRADITIONS

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 4/12: MAURYAN TO POST-MAURYAN
- IMPERIAL LINE pillars → capitals → polish → state authority
- POPULAR / RITUAL LINE

MECHANISM

- Yaksha / Yakshi → fertility / nature cults → absorption into major traditions
- Shalabhanjika → auspicious tree figure → long survival
- Narrative relief → stupa railings and gateways → symbolic Buddha presence

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Court art and popular motifs coexist; one does not cancel the other.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Court art and popular motifs coexist; one does not cancel the other.

04

STAGE 04 THREE-SCHOOL COMPARISON

THREE-SCHOOL COMPARISON · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 5/12 · GANDHARA MATHURA AMARAVATI · MATERIAL CLUE · SAFEST SIGNIFICANCE · GREY STONE · MAINLY BUDDHIST · LAYERED EXTERNAL VISUAL IDIOM

School	Material clue	Scope	Safest significance
Gandhara	grey stone / stucco	mainly Buddhist	layered external visual idiom
Mathura	spotted red sandstone	Buddhist + Hindu + Jain	indigenous shared image grammar
Amaravati	Krishna-valley relief	mainly Buddhist	dynamic narrative storytelling

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 5/12: GANDHARA MATHURA AMARAVATI
- Material clue
- Safest significance
- grey stone / stucco
- mainly Buddhist

MECHANISM

- layered external visual idiom
- spotted red sandstone
- Buddhist + Hindu + Jain
- indigenous shared image grammar
- Krishna-valley relief

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- dynamic narrative storytelling
- FINAL RULE
- Compare on the same axis: material, patronage, visual logic and significance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Compare on the same axis: material, patronage, visual logic and significance.

05

STAGE 05 ANICONISM AND ICONIC SHIFT

ANICONISM AND ICONIC SHIFT · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 6/12 · SYMBOL TO IMAGE · EARLY BUDDHIST SYMBOL SET EMPTY THRONE · GREAT RENUNCIATION · BODHI TREE · ENLIGHTENMENT WHEEL · FIRST SERMON STUPA

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 6/12: SYMBOL TO IMAGE

EARLY BUDDHIST SYMBOL SET empty throne → Great Renunciation → Bodhi tree / Vajrasana → Enlightenment wheel / lion / deer → First Sermon stupa → SHIFT RULE → Aniconism is symbolic presence, not absence.

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 6/12: SYMBOL TO IMAGE
- EARLY BUDDHIST SYMBOL SET empty throne → Great Renunciation

MECHANISM

- Bodhi tree / Vajrasana → Enlightenment wheel / lion / deer → First Sermon stupa → Parinirvana
- SHIFT RULE

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Aniconism is symbolic presence, not absence.
- Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerge in overlapping Gandhara and Mathura contexts.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Anthropomorphic Buddha images emerge in overlapping Gandhara and Mathura contexts.

06

STAGE 06 GUPTA BRIDGE AND DATING CAUTION

GUPTA BRIDGE AND DATING CAUTION · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 7/12 · GUPTA RESTRAINT · SARNATH IDIOM CREAM-COLOURED SANDSTONE THIN DRAPERY SUBTLE MODELLING SERENE · SULTANGANJ COPPER BUDDHA IS SAFER AS LATE · SERENITY ALONE IS NOT ENOUGH; MATERIAL AND CONTEXT MUST

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 7/12: GUPTA RESTRAINT

SARNATH IDIOM cream-coloured sandstone thin drapery subtle modelling serene controlled face → Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer as late / post-Gupta. → Serenity alone is not enough; material and context must agree.

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 7/12: GUPTA RESTRAINT
- SARNATH IDIOM cream-coloured sandstone thin drapery subtle modelling serene controlled face

MECHANISM

- Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer as late / post-Gupta.
- Serenity alone is not enough; material and context must agree.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 7/12: GUPTA RESTRAINT
- SARNATH IDIOM cream-coloured sandstone thin drapery subtle modelling serene controlled face

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Serenity alone is not enough; material and context must agree.

07

STAGE 07 SOUTH INDIAN PROGRAMME

SOUTH INDIAN PROGRAMME · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 8/12 · TEMPLE SURFACE AND RITUAL · DECORATIVE FORCE · GROUPED ICON BANK MUSICAL PILLARS · SCULPTURAL-PERFORMANCE LINK · MARRIAGE RITUAL RENDERED VISUALLY BRONZE ICONS · PORTABLE PROCESSIONAL PRESENCE

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 8/12: SOUTH INDIAN PROGRAMME

TEMPLE SURFACE AND RITUAL → Kirtimukha → threshold / decorative force → Saptamatrikas → grouped icon bank musical pillars → sculptural-performance link

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 8/12: SOUTH INDIAN PROGRAMME
- TEMPLE SURFACE AND RITUAL

MECHANISM

- Kirtimukha → threshold / decorative force
- Saptamatrikas → grouped icon bank musical pillars → sculptural-performance link

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Kalyanasundara → marriage ritual rendered visually bronze icons → portable processional presence
- Read motif, grouping and ritual use together.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Kalyanasundara → marriage ritual rendered visually bronze icons → portable processional presence.

08

STAGE 08 NATARAJA CHRONOLOGY

NATARAJA CHRONOLOGY · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 9/12 · NATARAJA TIMELINE · RAVANA PHADI, AIHOLE · EARLIEST KNOWN EXAMPLE IN THIS SOURCE BANK · PROVES PRE-CHOLA ANTECEDENT · CHOLA BRONZES · LOST-WAX CANONICAL PORTABLE FORM

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 9/12: NATARAJA TIMELINE

Ravana Phadi, Aihole → earliest known example in this source bank → proves pre-Chola antecedent → Chola bronzes

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 9/12: NATARAJA TIMELINE
- Ravana Phadi, Aihole
- earliest known example in this source bank

MECHANISM

- proves pre-Chola antecedent
- Chola bronzes
- lost-wax canonical portable form

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- temple procession and ritual visibility
- Do not mistake the most famous form for the first form.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Do not mistake the most famous form for the first form.

09

STAGE 09 ICONOGRAPHIC READING VOCABULARY

ICONOGRAPHIC READING VOCABULARY · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 10/12 · ICONOGRAPHIC CODE MUDRA · WHAT THE HAND SAYS ATTRIBUTE · WHO THE FIGURE IS VEHICLE · SECTARIAN AND SPATIAL CLUE ATTENDANT · NARRATIVE OR RITUAL CONTEXT POSTURE · SACRED MODE

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 10/12: ICONOGRAPHIC CODE mudra → what the hand says attribute → avayudha → who the figure is vehicle / placement → sectarian and spatial clue attendant / → grouping → narrative or ritual context posture → action / mood / sacred mode → Identification and interpretation are linked, but only through context.

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 10/12: ICONOGRAPHIC CODE mudra → what the hand says attribute /
- avayudha → who the figure is vehicle / placement → sectarian and spatial clue attendant /

MECHANISM

- grouping → narrative or ritual context posture → action / mood / sacred mode
- Identification and interpretation are linked, but only through context.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 10/12: ICONOGRAPHIC CODE mudra → what the hand says attribute /
- avayudha → who the figure is vehicle / placement → sectarian and spatial clue attendant /

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Identification and interpretation are linked, but only through context.

10

STAGE 10 ANIMAL-SYMBOL CHAIN

ANIMAL-SYMBOL CHAIN · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 11/12 · LION AND BULL ACROSS MEDIA · HARAPPAN BULL · VISIBLE, MEANING BOUNDED · MAURYAN CAPITALS · IMPERIAL AND SACRED CODING · SARNATH ABACUS

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 11/12: LION AND BULL ACROSS MEDIA

Harappan bull → visible, meaning bounded → Mauryan capitals → imperial and sacred coding → Sarnath abacus → lion and bull in one Buddhist programme

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 11/12: LION AND BULL ACROSS MEDIA
- Harappan bull → visible, meaning bounded
- Mauryan capitals → imperial and sacred coding

MECHANISM

- Sarnath abacus → lion and bull in one Buddhist programme
- Nandi mandapa → Shaiva bull with architectural place
- Yali / Vyala → leonine-hybrid guardians in later temple surface

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- Motif continuity survives; exact meaning changes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Yali / Vyala → leonine-hybrid guardians in later temple surface.

11

STAGE 11 SOCIAL EVIDENCE AND TERRACOTTA CONTINUITY

SOCIAL EVIDENCE AND TERRACOTTA CONTINUITY · ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 12/12 · FINAL SYNTHESIS · SOCIAL EVIDENCE SCULPTURE SHOWS PATRON-SELECTED VISIBILITY, RITUAL, DRESS, GESTURE · IT DOES NOT GIVE A FULL PHOTOGRAPHIC CENSUS OF · TERRACOTTA CONTINUITY · HARAPPAN FIGURINES · CHANDRAKETUGARH CRAFTSMANSHIP

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 12/12: FINAL SYNTHESIS

SOCIAL EVIDENCE sculpture shows patron-selected visibility, ritual, dress, gesture, performance and craft. → It does not give a full photographic census of society. → TERRACOTTA CONTINUITY → Harappan figurines / models

CORE CLAIM

- ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 12/12: FINAL SYNTHESIS
- SOCIAL EVIDENCE sculpture shows patron-selected visibility, ritual, dress, gesture, performance and craft.
- It does not give a full photographic census of society.
- TERRACOTTA CONTINUITY

MECHANISM

- Harappan figurines / models
- Chandraketugarh craftsmanship
- Gupta plaques
- Bengal terracotta-brick facades

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- FINAL RULE
- Every answer should end with one honest evidentiary limit.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Every answer should end with one honest evidentiary limit.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · 1. HIGH-VALUE FACTUAL CONTROLS · 2. COMPARATIVE ANSWER FRAMEWORK · 3. PROVENANCE AND CONSERVATION CAUTION · 4. TERRACOTTA CONTINUITY, HONESTLY BOUNDED · THE SCRIPT ON HARAPPAN SEALS REMAINS UNDECIPHERED, SO FAMOUS · THE EARLIEST KNOWN NATARAJA IN THIS TOPIC'S VERIFIED BANK · THE SULTANGANJ COPPER BUDDHA IS SAFER DESCRIBED AS LATE

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- 1. High-value factual controls
- 2. Comparative answer framework
- 3. Provenance and conservation caution
- 4. Terracotta continuity, honestly bounded

ADVANCED DEBATE

- The script on Harappan seals remains undeciphered, so famous labels remain hypotheses, not self-certified identities.
- The earliest known Nataraja in this topic's verified bank is at Ravana Phadi, Aihole; Chola achievement is canonical refinement, not origin.
- The Sultanganj copper Buddha is safer described as late or post-Gupta.
- In the verified Harappan evidence bank used here, cow and lion are absent from seals-and-terracotta representations.

LEGACY / NUANCE

- The source bank supports Amaravati recovery, removal and ASI-conservation discussion.
- It does not automatically verify present museum room, current display label or active repatriation status for each object.
- When a question demands live status, move only with dated official institutional evidence.
- The topic securely owns a continuity argument from Harappan figurines

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels